The Adventures of Captain Neato-Man

By Timothy Scott Harris

LARRY: *(leans through an open door as he rings the buzzer)* Hello?

MOTHER: *(Off -- Screaming)* Who's there?

LARRY: I'm sorry. I've come for . . .

MOTHER: *(Enters)* What?!

LARRY: *(Enters cautiously, carrying a newspaper clipping in his hand)* I'm sorry. I must have the wrong. . .

MOTHER: I'm an old woman. I need my rest. Are you here for the ad?

LARRY: Uh, yes.

MOTHER: Why didn't you say so? Son! Horatio is here!

INTRODUCTION

The Adventures of Captain Neato-Man by Timothy Scott Harris reminds me of the things my brothers and I would make up when we were kids. Hopping from the couch to the coffee table as if we were leaping across rooftops in pursuit of dastardly criminals. I even had my own cape made out of one of mom's dishtowels.

The Adventures of (DUH-DU-DUH!) Captain Neato-Man (echo, echo, echo) by Timothy Scott Harris

Captain Neato-Man bounds onto the stage. He wears high boots, tights, a Speedo with a belt around it that carries his special gadgets, a tight-fitting shirt, and a cape with his name on it.

CAPTAIN: Horatio, my boy, you're alive, alive! You don't know how long I've waited for this moment. Stick with me and you'll be a man. We shall tackle the cosmos together and our names shall live as one.

LARRY: I'm sorry, my name is Larry. Larry Friedman. I . . .

CAPTAIN: Larry. Horatio. What's the difference? You answered the ad, didn't you? Well, there you go. What are you complaining about?

LARRY: I thought this was a typing job.

CAPTAIN: Are you a communist?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

LARRY: No.

CAPTAIN: Then you're on my side. You are perfect, Horatio. Say you'll join my team.

LARRY: What's going on here?

CAPTAIN: Quick. If you looked up and noticed a baby falling right towards you. What would you do?

LARRY: Catch it?

CAPTAIN: It took me two weeks to pass the baby test, and you did it on the first try!

LARRY: Aw, it was nothing.

CAPTAIN: Modest . . . a superhero's most important virtue. Do you understand how incredible our potential can be if we band together?

LARRY: No.

CAPTAIN: The fame.

LARRY: *(sarcastic)* Right.

CAPTAIN: The glory.

LARRY: *(sarcastic)* Right.

CAPTAIN: The women.

LARRY: The women?

CAPTAIN: Yes, thousands of adoring beauties clamoring for you to write personal inscriptions on their [bodies].

LARRY: Wow.

CAPTAIN: And the monetary rewards are incredible.

LARRY: Money?

CAPTAIN: Sure. You can make a fast fifty just for saving a fat lady's cat.

LARRY: I'm good with animals.

CAPTAIN: And if you do really well, the mayor will give you the key to the city . . . Exciting, isn't it?

LARRY: Great. What do I have to do for all that?

CAPTAIN: Simple, just jump off a tall building. . . or walk through a blazing fire.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

LARRY: But I'd burn.

CAPTAIN: Not if you're a superhero.

LARRY: I'm not.

CAPTAIN: That's because you don't believe in yourself. Say you'll do it. Say it!

LARRY: I really appreciate the offer, but I'm not the type.

CAPTAIN: Type. There is no such thing as type. It's not ***what*** you are, but ***who*** you are. How does a caterpillar turn into a butterfly? How does a seed turn into a flower? How does a larva turn into a leech? They change from the inside. Only ***you*** can decide who you are. You can go on being Larry the Larva, or you can be "Horatio" the defender of justice and sidekick to . . . "Captain Neato Man."

LARRY: That all sounds wonderful. It's just that I'm not qualified.

CAPTAIN: What have you done?

LARRY: Mowed lawns, baby sat, worked at McDonald's.

CAPTAIN: McDonald's. The epitome of the American dream. It was fate that brought you here.

LARRY: But I liked McDonald's. They were going to make me assistant manager soon.

CAPTAIN: Then why did you answer the ad? The ad clearly states, "Be a real life superhero."

LARRY: Please, I thought it was time for a change, but I was wrong. I'm afraid I'll have to . . . leave.

CAPTAIN: You can't leave.

LARRY: Why? *(pause)*

CAPTAIN: Because the door is locked and only I can open it.

LARRY: Let me out or I'll scream.

CAPTAIN: Nobody will hear you. The walls are soundproof.

LARRY: If you don't let me out, I'll hit you, I swear.

CAPTAIN: *(laughing)* With my superpowers? Besides, you're too nice. *(They face off until Larry backs down)*

LARRY: Ok. Ok. I'll give you a chance. I'll stay . . . I'll stay . . . *(Larry picks up the phone and tries to dial, but there is no dial tone)* Operator. Operator.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

CAPTAIN: That's a special phone. It only takes incoming calls. The police commissioner has the number. Whenever there is a problem he can't handle, he calls me.

LARRY: Oh, I see. How often does he call? . . . On the average . . . how many times a week?

CAPTAIN: I can't give that information out to just anyone.

LARRY: He never calls. Does he?

CAPTAIN: He knows I'm here. He's just a very busy man. As a matter of fact, he sent some people over just last week to talk with me.

LARRY: He thinks you're crazy.

CAPTAIN: You don't know. You weren't here. I'm a superhero!

LARRY: Then prove it to me, and I'll stay.

CAPTAIN: Neato! You won't be sorry, Horatio. That's the spirit. Now try on your suit!

LARRY: You haven't proven anything yet.

CAPTAIN: Oh, still uptight, are we? You know, without your suit, your superpowers are greatly diminished. The special fabric is a unique nylon and acrylic blend. It's resilient to blows which would otherwise be fatal . . . Jeez. How much proof do you need?

LARRY: Anything. Show me anything.

CAPTAIN: I see. I was going to save this 'til later, but if you insist . . . My secret weapon!

(Captain pulls two identical toy guns out of a box. They look incredibly cheap and plastic. He hands one to Larry and puts the other in his belt.)

LARRY: Where did you get these? A box of Cocoa Puffs?

CAPTAIN: I saved box tops for six months.

LARRY: You are insane.

CAPTAIN: No. You don't understand. The shape and size of this toy gun was exactly what I needed to create the perfect weapon. With a few minor alterations it became . . . THE LAZOMATIC! This baby can shoot a laser beam accurately up to 3,000 feet, annihilating anything in its path.

LARRY: Ooohhh. Wow.

CAPTAIN: Want to test it? OK. Aim at that plant. What are you waiting for? Shoot the fern.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

(Larry aims at the fern and shoots. The gun makes a funny noise. Nothing else happens. He looks at the gun and tries again. Still nothing. He shoots at his head. Same thing. Captain grabs the gun and starts fiddling with it)

LARRY: It doesn't work. It's a toy.

CAPTAIN: That's because you didn't believe

LARRY: I'm not an idiot . . .

CAPTAIN: It just needs a few adjustments, that's all.

LARRY: I know you're crazy, but you can do this on your own. You don't need me. Give it a try. What are you afraid of?

CAPTAIN: I fear nothing. I'm a superhero! . . . I think it's best to have a partner, that's all. I mean sure I could do it myself, but I've been waiting for a partner.

LARRY: Then why don't you team up with . . . Superman?

CAPTAIN: What are you? Some kind of lunatic. There is no Superman. That's make believe. It's only a story.

LARRY: What about Batman?

CAPTAIN: Batman's real, but he's getting old. He can't do it all on his own, and you know about Robin.

LARRY: You see. I don't care. I just don't care.

CAPTAIN: He sold out. Went into real estate. Look, it's up to us now. We are the world's only hope. You can't walk away from your duty. The crime rate is outrageous. Disney is making horror pictures, and you don't care?

LARRY: Oh, please.

CAPTAIN: You want to believe me. Deep down you're intrigued. Admit it. Why did you answer the ad?

LARRY: I don't have a job.

CAPTAIN: You quit McDonald's.

LARRY: No.

CAPTAIN: Then they fired you!

LARRY: Yes.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

CAPTAIN: McDonald's ***fired*** you? What a loser . . . No . . . It was meant to be. That's why you're here.

LARRY: Let me go. You don't need me. A tough guy like you can handle this job on your own. I'm worthless. I would only get in the way.

CAPTAIN: Nonsense, Horatio. You see, every superhero needs a sidekick to share in the pure joy of his manly virtues.

LARRY: Couldn't your Mother do that?

CAPTAIN: Of course not. In order for our duo to work at its most effective level, it is essential they share a common bond. The kind of bond only a man can experience with another man. Say you'll bond with me and glory will be yours. History will record us as the two heroes in bondage together. Don't be afraid of chance. Try it . . . You like doing nothing, don't you. It's your life. Letting time slip away. Just slip away . . .

LARRY: How dare you say that about me. Look at you. You're a fake. A fool. Your life is no better than mine. Look at this place you live in. It's a dump. A dump.

CAPTAIN: You're right. It's a dump, but it's my dump and everything in my dump has a purpose. I'm here because I choose to be here. You've never chosen anything in your life. You're taking the easy way out.

LARRY: You're the one who's taking the easy way out.

CAPTAIN: Easy! You think it's easy being a superhero? You think I like walking through brick walls? Don't let this suit fool you. It's no picnic, and no magic fairy endowed me with superpowers, either. It took hard work and determination. You should know what that is. You worked at McDonald's.

LARRY: But don't you see, I even failed at that.

CAPTAIN: Horatio. I know.

LARRY: What do you know?

CAPTAIN: I know what it's like to be nothing. I was a failure too. I've spent most of my life feeling alone. Wishing I were dead, or just that I could be somebody else, anybody else. And when I thought there was no hope left, something happened. All at once I came alive.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I realized my whole life was a test. And at that moment, I began shaping the great man you see today. I got off my butt and started exercising. I built my body into the perfect machine and now I'm ready to save the world. Who's the bravest in the land?

LARRY: CAPTAIN NEATO-MAN!

CAPTAIN: I know you think I'm crazy. Maybe I am, but for the first time in my life I'm happy, and I know you can't say the same.

LARRY: But this stuff isn't real.

CAPTAIN: Anything can be real. We create realities all the time. How can you cling so desperately to your truth without knowing what truth is.

LARRY: We could die.

CAPTAIN: Be a hero, Horatio. I need you.

LARRY: No, I'm Larry . . . Larry . . .

CAPTAIN: Let go, Horatio. We could go down in history. *(he strikes his superhero pose and Larry wavers)*

LARRY: *(voice cracking)* Horatio! My name is Horatio *(Larry joins the Captain in a superhero pose)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Timothy Scott Harris
Book: Off-Off Broadway Festival Plays – 15th Series
ISBN: 978-0573692406
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): July 2017

AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier - MS
2023 National Qualifier
NIETOC
IN State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier